My Story - Rachel Helfgott

My name is Rachel Shafrir from the Helfgott family.

I was born on May 4, 1914, in the city of **Stryj**, which was in Poland, 70 kilometers from the big city of **Lviv**.

Stryj was a city of about 40,000 residents, among them 14,000 Jews, and the rest were mostly Poles and Ukrainians.

Stryj had a large synagogue, a Hebrew school, and vibrant Zionist activities. Most of the Jews in Stryj made a living from trade and included merchants, pharmacies, shop owners, and small business owners.

My father Moshe helfgot, was a prominent teacher at the Hebrew school called “A Clear Language” - שפה ברורה.

My grandfather, my father’s father, was the most devout of all – a Hasidic Jew, a rabbi, and a scribe. My grandfather forbade my father from studying any religious studies, as he was particularly strict about studying Gemara (Talmud) and Mishna.

My father believed that a life outside the religion was interesting and eye opening, so he studied In secret, philosophy, biology, languages – German and Polish – Polish literature, German and Polish history, secular sciences, and more.

My grandparents on my father’s side – Yitzhak and Rivka Helfgott – are buried at the Jewish cemetery on Mount of Olives in Jerusalem.

My father left home at a very young age. Despite his poor secular education, he was wise enough to become an auto deduct and work as a bookkeeper until 1912.

After that, he was accepted as a teacher at the Hebrew school “Clear Language.” My father loved teaching so much that he would sing to the students to keep them engaged.

It was difficult to make a living outside of religion in that period, so he gave private lessons in the evenings in Talmud and Hebrew. At our home, there were Zionist activities all the time. Our home was like a gathering house (Beit Va’ad) for Zionist work and township zionists were custom to gather in our home.

Our family was zionist in every sense, not associated with a specific zionist stand.

My father read the Hebrew newspapers “***HaTzvi***” and ***“HaHerut”*** (the liberty) In Stryj, several Zionist youth movements were active: the ***“Zionist Youth Union”***, ***“The Guard”*** and “***Beitar***.”

One of my father's brothers even ended up in a prison (Bereza Kartuska Prison) due to his participation in a pro-communist underground organization movement named the ***"bondits"***.

My father expressed opposition to the Beitar's "brown shirts" (brown color stands for appreciation of the land) zionism - he disliked the revisionists strand of zionist.

I did not join any specific zionist youth movement that operated in Stryj, but I did participate in the Hebrew community there as a student.

As a child I liked to sing and I joined the Hebrew choir and I had a leading position there singing in hebrew.

At home, we always thought of ourselves as zionist, we even had a **Keren Kayemeth Le-Israel (KKL**) blue donation box, and we always made sure to speak Hebrew.

My father was extremely strict about this. I remember once, during a walk in Stryj the nearby train station on kolyobka blvd, we spoke Hebrew between ourselves, and a woman standing next to us asked whether the language we were speaking was French.

My father answered proudly, "No, it's the bible language which the prophets have spoken." The woman responded in surprise, "How beautiful it sounds in the ears…" At that moment I was very proud to be a part of our long heritage.

My mother, Tonchaya Brettler came from the Brettler family, she was born to Leibe & Rachel Brettler, I was named after her.

The Bartal family was well-known and respected. My maternal grandmother, Rachel, came from a family of scholars and intellectuals. She came from the family of the well-known geographer Professor Braver, who taught at Mount Carmel in the University of Haifa.

My mother was primarily a housewife—a caregiver for six children, three of whom were my father's from a previous marriage who died during childbirth.

My mother cared for everyone with so much love that I only found out at the age of 12 that my brothers were born to a different mother. My mother only graduated the fifth class, but her behavior was a model for morality, wisdom and mother love.

My mother's attitude and affection was a model for the education of my own children.

She was our family's psychologist and sociologist without even knowing it herself. Once a week a cleaning woman would come, and my mother treated her as if she were a close relative: she would serve her food and make sure she wouldn't strain herself too much with cleaning.

My mother was so compassionate that when a group of people came in, the one who stood out in the worst clothes—she would bring him a bowl of water with soap and a towel to wash up.

The jewish community was not wealthy and baggers were a common sight. Often my mother would welcome a poor man asking for money in our house, she would give him a bowl of water and soap so he could clean himself, and an old shirt of my father he could use.

Despite the fact that we ourselves were a poor family and often fought for a living - our spirit was high and we had agency and pride in our tradition and culture.

My mother and father made sure we never felt that we lacked anything in our daily lives.

My Siblings:

In the family there were three brothers and two sisters. The three eldest children were born to my father from his first wife Yenta.

Yenta of the shenfeld family married my father in 1901. In 1902, my eldest sister Miriam was born. In 1903, my brother Shaul was born, and in 1905, my brother Pishko was born.

Yenta died during Pishko's childbirth. My father grieved her passing and only after four years (1909) he remarried my mother.

I was born on the fourth of may 1914, my younger brother Izo (Isaac) was born on november 10th 1921.

My eldest sister Miriam had graduated high school during 1920 when I was only six years old. Miram later started studying pharmaceuticals at the university of Krakow. At the age of 25 she finished her university studies and started working in a pharmacy in our town Stryj.

My sister Miriam married Wolf Pepper who was my cousin from my father's side, Wolf was the son of Fruma Pepper (helfgot) - my father's sister. in 1930 my sister Miram had birthed Julek (Isack) and he was her only child.

Her husband worked on lumber trade & leasing of forest property for the purpose of cutting them down and trading.

Once my sister married she stopped working until she gave birth. She returned to her profession as a pharmacist when Julek has grown a little and she could leave him with a caretaker.

In 1939 as part of the Ribentrob-Molotove agreement between nazi germany and soviet russia to partition poland between them our town was taken by the russian soviet army.

My sister continued working as a pharmacist for the Russians, in 1941 Natzi Germany invaded Russia and also took over Poland.
During the red army retreat they offered my sister & her family to join them to the East. My sister did not see the coming [future] and refused to join. After the German occupation, we fell into the hands of the Nazi reign of terror. My sister continued to work as a pharmacist in Stryi even after the German occupation. An incident occurred one day at the pharmacy when a German officer discovered that my sister, who worked there, was Jewish. He said to her with loathing: "This is a disgrace to our race," and as he said this, he wiped his hands on his

uniform as a symbol of the disgust and shame he felt. At that very moment, she was expelled from her job at the pharmacy.

Thanks to her husband's connections, the entire family received work at a sawmill. This was hard physical labor, yet everyone wanted to work there because the workers received the status of "laborers," and since they contributed to the "German war effort," they were among the last to be murdered by the Nazis. As the liquidation of the ghetto approached, my sister felt her end was near and obtained two doses of poison for herself and her son. On one of the occasions I visited her home, she told me that when the time comes, she will know how to use the poison. Her son, who overheard our conversation from the next room, said: "Mom, I am still young and have experienced almost nothing in life, I don't want to die, Mom!" Three months after that conversation, I met with my sister's family again. Her son Yulek had matured beyond recognition, both in his appearance and in his soul. This time he said to me in one of the conversations we had: "If the hour comes and we are caught by the Nazis, I will ask my mother to give me the dose (the dose of poison) first, so as not to see her death..." In the final *Aktion* of the ghetto, my sister Miriam was taken with her family to the "Holobutow" forest near Stryi, and there, apparently, an end was put to her life and the life of her son.

My brother Saul completed his high school studies in 1921. That same year, he went to study in Belgium because in Poland he could not study due to the "Numerus Clausus" that was practiced in Poland. My brother studied in Liège, which is in Belgium. In the morning he studied engineering and the French language, and in the evening he worked in the coal mines to fund his studies and livelihood. Despite the difficult lifestyle, my brother physically completed his law studies with honors as an engineer.

My eldest brother mastered (reading and writing) 12 languages; he was indeed, without a doubt, a man of talents. After completing his academic studies, he was offered a job as a bridge engineer in the Belgian Congo (today it is Zaire). Because of his Jewishness, he could not work as an engineer in Poland, so he had no reason to return to Poland. Saul accepted the job offer and traveled to Africa. During a vacation, he came to Poland to visit us. During one of the trips to visit his uncle Abraham Wolf, who lived in Czechia, he met the daughter of the uncle, named Alzia—his future wife. My father expressed displeasure at the closeness between the groom and the bride's family because the bride's mother, Sarah, was my father's sister. However, after persuasions in which I took a central part, he relented and agreed to be present at the wedding.

After Saul married Alzia, he returned to the Congo. In the Congo, his only daughter, Irene, was also born. In 1945, towards the end of the war, while he was still in the Congo, he planned at that time to take from Europe the daughter of my brother Pishko—his younger brother from the trio of older brothers, the only survivor of our extensive family—but Saul died in the Belgian Congo due to a complication from appendicitis.

Two years after his death, his daughter Irene died of polio. His wife, my widowed sister-in-law Alzia, immigrated to Israel after the death of her family. Throughout our lives in the country, Alzia and I made sure to meet frequently. Alzia passed away in 1974, a short time after she immigrated to the country. She was 59 years old at the time of her death and is buried in Givat Shaul in Jerusalem.

The second brother, the youngest of the great trio, was **Pishko**. Pishko completed his studies in 1923 and specialized in accounting. Pishko worked and lived in the town of Synowódzko Wyżne, a 45-minute journey from Stryi. Pishko was very talented in manual labor and would build wooden pieces, miniature dollhouses, clocks, and perfect models of towers. He also built delicate and charming frames that were not difficult to sell. Additionally, he was a photography enthusiast and developed the films he produced himself. I will always remember my brother Pishko as a gentle and sensitive soul who loved to dance and spend time out; he would always come home and burst into medleys of whistles that were wonderfully artistic.

My brother Pishko married **Adzia Gottlieb** in 1933, the daughter of the Gottlieb family who lived in the town of Sambor, northwest of Stryi. In 1934, a daughter named Anita was born to him. My second brother also established a family, but the Nazi hand found him too. Before the start of the *Aktions* in Synowódzko, Pishko felt the end of the Jews was near and left his daughter Anita outside the ghetto in the hands of friends—a Christian Polish family. He did so with the thought that if he or someone from his family were saved, they would surely gather her back into the family fold. In 1942, Adzia's parents were also murdered during one of the *Aktions* in Sambor. My brother's wife was murdered first by the Nazis and he was shot to death as he tried to cross the river that divides the city of Synowódzko at night. His body was buried nearby.

Anita was saved thanks to the resourcefulness of her father and from the immediate Nazi threat; she now lives in Toronto, Canada and has established an exemplary family.

Despite the geographical distance, we strive to maintain frequent contact, and sometimes Anita and her family come to visit the country and we receive them with open arms.

My younger brother **Izio (Yitzhak)** was born on October 10, 1921. He completed his studies in 1939 and lived with his parents. My brother was an active member of the youth movement "HaShomer HaTzair" in Stryi. There was a seven-year gap between us, and therefore I loved to help my mother care for my little brother. My mother used to say that I was very close to him and was like a second mother to him. When we grew up we became very good friends and I was like a loving older sister and also a playmate.

In 1939, before the Russians entered and conquered Stryi, the Germans carried out a sudden abduction due to circumstances and lawlessness and took over the region intended for the Russians, including Stryi. This part of the German occupation lasted only four days, but it was to signal the coming horrors from the Nazis. As soon as the Germans approached, my brother fled to the Russian territory until the Germans left. After more than a month, he returned to Stryi which was under Soviet rule. In 1941, when the Germans conquered Poland from the Russians, my brother fled with two friends and since then his tracks have disappeared. I learned from my father's students that he was last seen in Taganrog, a Russian port city on the Sea of Azov, which connects from the south to the Black Sea.

I myself studied in a Polish elementary and high school. After completing high school, I tried to be accepted into a Polish teachers' seminar but was not accepted because of my Jewishness. Therefore, I studied in a private Ukrainian teachers' seminar that was recognized by the Polish Ministry of Education. I studied Jewish subjects in the "Higher [Institute] for Judaism" in Lviv at about the age of twenty. After graduating from the teachers' seminar in 1933, I tried to be accepted as a teacher to work in a Polish and Ukrainian school in Stryi, but I was rejected by both with various excuses that were rooted in my being Jewish. Since I could not work in a school setting, I was forced to earn my bread by giving private lessons in Hebrew and for circles invited for Judaism. I also gave private lessons to Polish students in general studies. Thus I was going "from street to street," from building to building, from apartment to apartment in order to give lessons and earn a little.

In 1939, I almost immigrated to Israel with my husband. However, because my parents were concerned about how I would manage alone in the Land of Israel, I did not leave and already later the war broke out. When the war broke out, the entire course of our lives stopped. According to the Molotov-Ribbentrop Pact, which was signed between Nazi Germany and the USSR, it was determined that the region of the country where we lived in Poland would pass to Soviet rule.

When we “passed” to Russian rule, everything changed and was overturned. The Hebrew school where my father taught was closed, and Father was left without work. Russian officials moved into our house, and we were forced to move into a "new" apartment consisting of only one and a half rooms, which had previously been a bakery.

Only two students remained for Father, taking private lessons. I accepted work as a teacher in a Ukrainian school located in a village not far from Boryslav called "Pod-Horodtsia" at the foot of the Carpathian Mountains. In this small Ukrainian village, there were educational institutions for about 500 students at the elementary school level—grades one to seven—and a small church. In this school, I taught grades four and up all subjects except for gymnastics. The reason I taught from grade four and not grade one is that I refused to say the Christian prayer and cross myself, something that grade one was required to do every morning. But as fate would have it that I would be a Christian teacher, I did this under Nazi rule. In the school itself there were overt displays of anti-Semitism but not personally toward me because I did not look like a "typical Jewess". To reach Pod-Horodtsia from Stryi, I traveled by train to Synowódzko Wyżne and stayed at my brother Pishko's house.

According to the orders of the new administration that arrived from Russia, we were required to teach in two shifts so that our studies actually lasted from early morning until evening. During my work, the authorities chose me for a "deputation for elections" of the region, a volunteer role that was considered a great honor. This was my first teaching position, and in practice, I taught there until the Russian retreat during the Nazi attack, "Operation Barbarossa".

I lived with a local priest's family because I knew how to play the violin—I had learned violin in Stryi from a "Kleizmer" amateur musician because he was the only teacher we could afford. I utilized the knowledge to teach the priest and his children named Vasil and Shomlo and his wife Maria. The children Nestor and Natalka received violin lessons from me in exchange for a room and breakfast.

In 1940 (still under Soviet rule) I met my future husband Willo Weinberg, whom I had first known in 1935. After a six-week romance, we married on September 6, 1940.

My husband Willo lived meanwhile with my parents while I taught in the village. Every Sunday with the vacation, I traveled home to Stryi to my parents and my husband. During a study break during my stay in Stryi in 1941, the Nazis invaded the Russian territory two years after the World War began and reached our house. Willo was drafted into the Russian army when I was in my fourth month of pregnancy... when we separated, it was the last time I saw him. I told him: "When you return you will find a son in my arms...". Willo did not get to see....

The winter of 1941 was extremely difficult. A heavy snow fell that covered the city in a deep white blanket. When I felt birth pangs and knew I was about to give birth, it was night and there was a curfew in the city. My mother walked together with me during the curfew toward the Jewish hospital, which was in the area that later became the ghetto. Around the hospital was a wall two meters high. We knocked on the gate no one answered, as they thought that at such a late hour the knockers could be Ukrainians coming to riot against Jews or Nazis. My elderly mother, at the age of 62, climbed the wall and crossed it to announce our arrival, and only then were the gates of the hospital opened. How did she do this!! She risked her life for her daughter...

After the birth, I stayed for three weeks in the hospital due to a high fever that afflicted me. A large part of that period I was unconscious. The doctor who treated me was Dr. Koenig, whose children I had taught in the past.

My father requested permission from me to circumcise the newborn and asked that his name be Amos, like the name of the prophet he loved. After the circumcision, the situation grew even worse. An unbearable situation prevailed in the city. Hard hunger, a lack of basic medicines, and therefore lice and difficult diseases prevailed in abundance. While I was gravely ill, my sister Miriam told my parents that I could die at home among the family as well, and therefore they brought me home. Like a kind of divine intervention...

The day after I left the hospital, Gestapo men arrived at the hospital equipped with machine guns and submachine guns and murdered the patients, the medical staff, and the infants in cold blood.

I lay in bed at home with a high fever and a breast infection (mastitis) and had no milk to give to my baby son, Amos. Suddenly, a Jewish man from the Land of Israel named Schechter appeared at our house. Schechter had come for a vacation and was stuck in Stryi from the beginning of the German invasion. He heard that my father had a large Hebrew library and so he became a close friend of the family. In his physical appearance, he resembled a non-Jew and worked as a cattle herder for non-Jews. He visited us occasionally, and tucked under his arm was a container of fresh milk that he hid under his clothes for Amos. He would appear at sunset and served as a redeeming angel. He used to encourage me by saying: "The war will end and we will travel in Israel from Dan to Beersheba" and I would add: "together with Milo"...

Every so often, the priest’s wife managed to sneak a bit of butter and cheese for my son Amos. Amos was a beautiful baby. He had blue eyes like his father and hair that was

completely blond, like an angel. After some time passed, we began to trade everything we had in the house for a little bit of food. We traded a new sheet for 4 liters of milk, a Singer sewing machine for 2 buckets of potatoes. We gave away the beds and showed all the little that remained. Father built wooden bunks from planks for us to sleep on instead of the beds we gave away and a cradle for Amos. Amos fell ill with dysentery, and Dr. Leibovitch, who was a friend of the family, said that he needed medicine called "Larosan" and apple puree. I left the ghetto which was not yet completely closed toward the Aryan neighborhoods. I took off the ribbon with the Star of David symbol from my sleeve and stepped to a Christian friend and asked her for "Larosan" and apples. I took my violin for sale in exchange for the medicine and the apples. Meanwhile, an "Aktion" broke out in the house with the elderly parents and I was on the Aryan side...

My friend hid me in the basement and put me into a barrel of laundry, because she was afraid of anti-Semitic neighbors. These were physical and emotional torments larger than the physical ones because all the time I was hidden I thought what would happen if the Nazis reached the house to the baby and the parents...

After two days of anxiety and suffering, I returned with a trembling heart to the house but to much luck the lot fell on our place, as by chance they skipped our house. Later on, Amos passed away from the difficult illness, my father watched over his body all night from the mice. After he passed away I suffered from a paralysis in my vocal cords and could not speak and communicated with the family with the help of hand signs. During the time of the paralysis Dr. Leibovitch came to visit me to check the paralysis that attacked me, she tried to comfort me and said that it was better that Amos passed away from illness and was not murdered by the Nazis, as she also had a child and feared for his fate. A friend of my brother took Amos's body wrapped in his father's coat to bring him to burial. On the way, S.S. men stopped him and ordered him to open the package he was carrying to check what "merchandise" he was transporting...

At night, I would wake up from a dream, hearing Amos's cry; I would light the candle and see that the cradle was empty... Afterward, Father took an axe and turned the cradle into firewood for heating. After my speech returned, I went to work at the sawmill together with my sister and brother-in-law. I obtained this job through protection.

A few days after I started working at the sawmill, another "Aktion" began in Stryi. The manager of the "Rigol" sawmill did not allow the workers to leave so that they would not be killed by the Nazis. We continued to work, hauling planks, and when the inspector appeared, we hauled even more planks. Suddenly, I saw a bird perched at the edge of the pile of planks next to my ear, and I imagined in my soul that it was Amos coming to visit me...

During that same "Aktion," we hid in the space between the ground and the pile of planks. The sawmill was close to the train station, on the tracks where they also transported Jews

death cars. From our hiding place, we heard the cries of the suffocating victims: "Water, water" (*woly, woly*). Afterward, the train whistle blew, and everything went silent—an oppressive silence. After the "Aktion" ended, I ran quickly home and found my parents safe and alive. Along the way, I saw Jews collecting the bodies of the dead, the slain. On the way, they caught me and forced me to assist in loading bodies onto the wagons.

Sometimes I brought wood scraps from the sawmill for heating, since wood was what we had kept as a cover during the time of the "Aktion". The Jew Schechter from the Land of Israel, who was stuck in Stryi, used to comfort me [by saying] that we would succeed in surviving the fury and stay alive until after the war. Schechter himself planned to join the partisans because we already knew the Nazis were about to establish a ghetto in Stryi, and after the establishment of the ghetto, it would no longer be possible to leave. The man indeed did so, but then his tracks disappeared and I do not know what became of him.

In November 1942, another "Aktion" broke out, and more than 1,000 Jews were caught. My father, before he was caught by the Nazis, reached us with the news that another "Aktion" was about to break out. However, my father did not want to hide again and remained at home with his sister, who was heart-sick. It seems he no longer had the mental strength, and he also feared for his sister with the heart condition.

My father was caught together with the rest of the Jews and they were concentrated in the Great Synagogue of Stryi, where they were concentrated for several days without food or drink. Those imprisoned in the synagogue screamed and shouted and scratched the walls with their fingernails, seeking revenge.

Mother, I, and the neighbors hid inside a small building in the yard where there were piles of wood organized in the shape of a wall, and in the space behind the cold wall we sat and waited for the judgment. Father was in the house. We heard the knocking of the boots of the murderers at the door accompanied by the Ukrainians who shouted and cursed the Jews.

Father, who heard the shouts, answered in fluent German: 'I am obeying the instructions of the German government,' and by doing so, he wanted to distract the Germans from the shed in which we were hiding. The Ukrainians broke down the door with kicks and broke and smashed in hatred the little that remained in the house, amid curses against the Jews.

Behind the wall, we heard the Ukrainians kicking the wooden beams surrounding us and prayed that they would not break into the shed. Thus we waited for two days in the shed, we and additional neighbors who hid in another place, until they came to our house and informed us that the Aktion had ended and it was possible to come out of hiding. After several days, I received a surprise through a man named Rosenberg - who was together with my father on the train that led to the death camps, he was a student of my father.

He has conveyed a greeting from Father. Rosenberg managed to escape from the train. Rosenberg told me that he explained to the passengers of the train, like his students in school, that there is no reason to cry; a day will come and the government of malice will pass from the land, and our children will merit redemption. This is the last regard from my father, my teacher. The house was empty and deserted, and on the bed that he built from sources that remained from his Talmud Torah school.

In Stryi, we knew an intelligent Ukrainian, one of the managers of the sawmill whose name was Borichko. To Borichko I gave 250 gold dollars, a diamond ring that Mother received from Father, and my gold wedding ring, a gold watch, and a gold necklace so that he would hide my mother and me. Borichko told me explicitly that he does not love Jews, but he wants to save us because he wanted to save the Ukrainian reputation in my eyes. Borichko had many connections and thus managed to hide us and several other Jews. The first hiding place he

found for us was with a Polish woman, a widow whose house was that of a 'prostitute by profession.' We only saw one client who came to the prostitute. In the house there were only two beds, one of them was that of the widow and the second served me and my mother. The bedding on the bed was still from the widow's husband who had passed away and they were very filthy; the widow did not change the dirty bedding, and we were forced to lie on the infected bed.

During the day we hid in the wardrobe, and at night we knitted socks for the widow and her daughter and repaired old clothes. While clients [came], we hid in the wardrobe. When we hid in the wardrobe, we occasionally crumpled the black scarf she had, and then Mrs. Liba poured [out her heart] to me and my mother with terrifying screams. When the prostitute and my mother left the house in the evenings, we sat by the window that was lit by a street lamp and knitted socks, and our ears were attentive to the door for any whisper that was from the other side. Every day we ate a thin cabbage soup and a slice of bread. Borichko managed to obtain forged Aryan papers for me and my mother.

We spent Christmas Eve in their home, and in the evening the prostitute got drunk and began to cry and lean on my shoulders and said to me: 'Marusia (Maria, as was my name in the forged Aryan papers), the war will end and you will be a teacher and I will return to being a prostitute'. In the last 'Aktion' of the Stryi Ghetto, the Nazis entered every house and searched thoroughly, and luckily for us, the oppressors did not enter the house where we hid. After a month’s time, we arrived at the home of the Polish widow; Borichko moved us to a Ukrainian family where we hid in the attic or in the cellar of the house. During the searches for Jews we hid for consecutive days in the attic, where during the day there was unbearable heat from the sun and the nights were freezing. One night in the attic, Mother dreamed that she was ascending to the heavens and angels in white were hovering around her. Mother interpreted the dream as her joining Father in heaven. This family also hid a Jewish woman named Schlechteruba and her four-year-old son. Schlechteruba hid in the same house, but Mother and I did not meet her during the first months we hid in the Ukrainians' home. After two months, the family demanded that Mother and I leave; when they informed us that we would be forced to leave, I notified Borichko so he would buy two portions of poison for me and for Mother.

The next day Borichko returned and changed his story; he said he would travel in a wagon with Schlechteruba and her son and I would follow behind the wagon, and they agreed to leave Mother there in the guise of an old grandmother. The next day the four of us set out toward the town. I had two blonde braids and they gave me a milk jug in my hand, and I looked as if I were a gentile girl returning from the market after I had sold milk in the market. I walked behind the wagon with steady steps; we crossed over the bridge over the Stryi River. On the way out of Stryi, an S.S. man passed in front of me with his threatening dog, and I bent over to the side, picked a flower, and gave him a confident smile. Borichko brought us to the forest. In the forest, we lay and hid among the trees for several days until the final liquidation of the ghetto. From a distance, the sound of wood-cutting could be heard. The forest guard was in contact with Borichko and would bring us a clump of earth inside his hat that contained a slice of bread, a bottle of water, and a little milk. The leaves served us as pillows and bedding. After six weeks in the forest, the forest guard took us to a Ukrainian village not far from Stryi.

In the Ukrainian village, we hid inside a fodder of straw for the cows where we hid throughout the day. Inside the straw where we lay, there was a kind of tube that served as a small skylight for the entry of air and sunlight. At the entrance to the hiding place, there was a square bale of straw; we would remove it to bring in food, and sometimes the hunter/provider would enter the hiding place himself. In the hiding place were I, Schlechteruba, and her son, and we were there for a month. During that month, the Germans arrived and searched the village to see if there were Jews in it. They stabbed the straw with rifle bayonets to check if someone was hiding in it; we all held our breath and Schlechteruba blocked her young son's mouth with her palm, but we were not hit and we were saved. Afterward, since the man with whom we hid did not want to keep us anymore.

Schlechteruba, her son, and I moved on; they were on the wagon and I was behind them with a basket in my hand. Borichko moved us to another Ukrainian family in a Ukrainian village called Niniów. I did not tell the Ukrainian family about my being Jewish and relied on the 'Aryan' papers that were in my possession. I worked at various jobs for the Ukrainian family and lived in constant anxiety: do they know about my being Jewish?! I prayed as a Christian, but all the while fear gnawed at me that perhaps they had already reported me to the German authorities. I asked Borichko for a cyanide pill so that if the need arose, I could poison myself and only not be caught by the Germans; I also kept a shaving razor in case he did not come... Borichko would come to visit frequently (mainly to see Schlechteruba, his beloved) and after a few days that I requested from him the poison, he moved me to an underground bunker in the Niniów area where I met Schlechteruba and her son and eight other Jews. In other bunkers, there was one family, the Rappaports. In the bunker, it was a bit more than a meter under the ground and was divided into four cells, and in each cell, its size was about two square meters and its height a bit less than a meter. In a cell, there were three people. In the cell, we were forced to walk bent over.

Outside the cells, they were covered with earth and supported by poles, and above us, cows grazed on the grass that grew over the cells. A kind-hearted Ukrainian named Kuzik lowered food and a little water to us, and at night he would remove the waste. Because there was a shortage of water, we could not wash, and I contracted infections and contaminations. Mrs. Rappaport began to go mad and thought she was a dancer and singer; she sang and danced, something that terrified us because we feared people above would hear the noise. The Rappaport family from the city of Zhydachiv consisted of three brothers and their families who had been in this hiding place since the beginning of the war between Russia and Germany. Mr. Rappaport feared his wife would betray him and their family, and therefore requested poison from the Ukrainian peasant Kuzik. Kuzik calmed him and promised him that nothing is heard from above the ground and there is no reason to fear because the Russians are at the doorstep and will very soon conquer the area and liberate the village. On Christmas, the peasant's wife descended and sang Christmas songs for us to lift our spirits. I taught the small children Hebrew and así felt that there was a taste to life. Borichko came to visit us frequently and took Schlechteruba to spend several hours with him.

Borichko told me to write letters to my mother and thus gave me the impression she was still alive.

We lived in hiding for 8 month until the russians liberated this part of Poland.

After the war

After the liberation by the Russians, we came out in the darkness of night and left toward Stryi. I returned to the family that had held my mother, believing that when she met me, she would run to me with open arms and hug me in her arms....

I reached the family and did not find Mother. I asked them where Mother was, if she had fallen ill, if she had died? What happened to her? Where is she? And they remained silent. Finally, they told me that the husband of Schlechteruba had come with his brother and threatened them that if they did not remove my mother and give him the hiding place, he would inform on them to the Germans; they were afraid of him and had no choice. Mother accepted this with understanding even though they had sentenced her to death, saying to them that they are good people, and she understands that they are afraid.

Mother wore a white ribbon around her right sleeve and on it was a prominent sewn Star of David in blue. She took the picture of Father and pressed it to her heart and intended to go to the Great Synagogue, the last place Father had been before he was led to the death camps. Mother did not manage to reach the synagogue; she was shot to death under a large chestnut tree near the church. The family gave me her black dress and the belt.

After the liberation, Schlechteruba's husband demanded that I testify against Borichko in a trial held under the Soviet government. Schlechteruba's husband knew about the affair his wife had with Borichko and thus tried to take revenge on him for it. I did not understand how I could do such a thing since Borichko saved his wife's life and the life of their son....

He asked me to testify against Borichko and I naturally refused to say anything false about Borichko; rather, I only told the truth in the trial: that he saved us and other Jews from the Nazis. After the liberation, I returned to Stryi to the house we had lived in; everything was neglected and destroyed. Everything was broken into, and neighbors told me that no Jews remained there anymore. I was told that there was a Jewish community of the 'Remnant of the Saving,' and I went to the community house to look for work as a teacher, as the Russians were once again the masters of the land. In Stryi, I did not find work, but I thought it was forbidden for me to leave Stryi because if anyone remained from the family—some brother or my husband—and if they were alive, they would look for me in Stryi. In Stryi, they offered me a job as the manager of 'ZAGS' (the civil registry office for births, marriages, etc.). My knowledge of the Russian language, which I learned in a course as part of my training during the period of the [first] Russian rule, helped me to get the position.

In the office there were two clerks; I was the office manager and a supervisor was above me. Jewish Holocaust survivors came to the office and requested documents because they had lost theirs, and I issued them documents with all the details they requested me to register. At that time, the repatriation of those who until 1939 were Polish citizens began, and masses of Poles began to leave the area where the Russians ruled. I remained because I feared that if I did not find one of my relatives in Stryi, they would not find me if they came looking for me.

After six months of work there, during which I received no sign of my relatives, I met a Russian captain in the registration office whose wife was Jewish, and he offered for me to

move to the military headquarters as a secretary. I refused and explained to him that I was waiting for one of my lost family members, and he promised me that as a captain in the Russian army, he would be able to clarify the fate of my husband, Wilo, who was a soldier in the Red Army.

He released me from my management work, and I moved to work as a secretary at the military headquarters as a volunteer with personal number 03778. The headquarters was located on a train and followed in the footsteps of the Russian army after the retreating Germans—about 3 km from the western front toward Berlin. The only documents I had in my possession were a work certificate as a secretary and a high school diploma that was rolled up in a tube of ointment.

The headquarters was attached to a mobile military hospital, and during my time at the headquarters with the soldiers and the wounded, I served them and occupied their time; I truly 'captured their hearts'. They found it difficult to believe I was Jewish, as I said I was a typical Russian girl. The head of the headquarters was Major Ronu, and throughout my time there, I requested him incessantly to search and inquire about my husband's fate. During German plane bombings, when all the soldiers at headquarters went down to the shelters, I remained in the office and continued to work, perhaps because I had become indifferent toward fate.

On one of the days we were bombed, a political officer entered the headquarters office and demanded to know what I was doing and why I was not in the shelter. I explained to him that I was not afraid of the planes, but he accused me of signaling the German planes where to bomb. At headquarters, there was a Georgian captain, a loathsome anti-Semite who harassed me and asked why the Jews did not fight the Nazis. One day, while the headquarters was in a town, I came across a cemetery where a Jewish man named Misha Swieczar Chaimowicz was buried, who had received medals of valor for his bravery. I pointed out the grave to the Georgian captain, because in one row the Jew received four medals of honor, and the Georgian remained silent. During the movement of the headquarters, a memorandum was published informing that the Poles refugees who lived within the borders of Poland until 1939 are entitled to return to the new borders of Poland. During the period when the headquarters was stationed in Bielsko, Poland, the USSR declared war on Japan, and the headquarters received an order to depart for the Far East. I approached the Major who was the Chief of Staff; I requested [to stay], as I had been a Polish citizen since before 1939 and I wished to remain in Poland. The Chief of Staff told me to write a formal written request, and so I did.

Two days later, in the middle of work, I was summoned to the **NKVD** room for interrogation. I arrived at the room, they locked the door behind me with a key, and sat me down across from an interrogator with a flashlight pointed at my eyes. He stared at me in silence for a few moments, and suddenly slammed his clenched fist hard on the table and shouted:

'You are a traitor to the motherland! You felt like moving to a capitalist country (Israel). We will trail you for collaborating with the Germans.' Explanations did not help him, that I am Jewish and had never collaborated with the Germans, and I even mentioned that I have a cousin who works on a Kolkhoz [Soviet collective farm].

None of this influenced him. Finally, I had enough. I stood up, pressed myself against the wall, spread my arms, and said to him:

'Shoot! What the Germans didn't finish, you finish.' This apparently settled his mind, and he released me to continue my work. To continue working, of course, I could not and I went to my friend, the physician **Dr. Walasiuk**, and his wife **Galina Borisovna**, who was the head nurse at the mobile military hospital attached to the headquarters. The doctor and his wife had been good friends since my visits to the military hospital. I felt respect and trust for them, and this feeling was mutual. I told Galina what had happened to me that day, and she told me that as long as the border is open, I should flee, because once we return to the USSR, I will not be able to leave. Galina and her husband were very enlightened, and we had many heart-to-heart conversations; during these talks, they told me they had no children because they did not want to raise children under such a regime.

I approached Dr. Walasiuk and asked him what to do regarding my request to leave. He suggested I write a **letter of regret**, stating that I wished to remain at the headquarters and that my request to move to Poland was a foolish act. Meanwhile, he would try on his part to speak with the Chief of Staff to ask him to release me from my position.

The next morning, I was summoned to the political officer—the **Politruk**. A more 'reconciliatory' interrogation began, in which I told him everything about myself. He asked why I had written a letter requesting to return to Poland, and I replied that I was searching for remnants of my family, that perhaps someone from them had survived. I also answered him [by referencing] **Chekhov's story** about Iona [Potapov], whose son died and he would wander among the crowd of people with no one to tell of his tragedy—that is how I felt. The Politruk was surprised by my knowledge of Russian literature and promised that if I remained loyal to the regime, I would yet reach greatness... I promised to stay and faithfully serve the regime and was released back to work, but from that day on, they watched my every step and did not let me wander outside the headquarters alone; instead, they assigned the anti-Semitic Georgian Captain to tail me.

We continued moving east toward the interior of Russia. We had already reached Krakow, but they did not let us leave the train in which we worked and slept, and only when the train stopped could we get off for the purpose of using the latrines. I already imagined to myself that I would never reach Israel, my beloved land.

And then, one morning before dawn, I left the train to use the latrines with my Jewish friend Ella (who currently lives in Israel) and I happened to meet a sleepy railway worker. I asked him where we were, and he replied in Polish that we were in **Przemysl** and that soon the train would cross the border. I thought this was a sign from God for me and I did not return to the train. I gave my friend the watch that was on my hand; I had on only a short jacket and 300 rubles. I told Ella that I was leaving, and she asked, 'What should I say to the Russians?' I replied to her that she should say she doesn't know where I am.

And so I parted from her [Ella] and continued on; I did not look back but walked away from the station toward the city center, the main thing being to get far from the train. As I walked the streets of this strange city, I suddenly bumped into a man in uniform who was a railway worker. He greeted me and asked if I didn't remember him. My heart skipped a beat, and he continued: 'I am **Mstry**, and you helped me with repatriation and quickly arranged all the

documents for me when I worked at the registration office in **Stryi**.' Only then did I breathe a sigh of relief.

He told me that in Przemyśl lived the wife of **Dr. Mondschein**, a lawyer whose children I had taught. He gave me her address (**Dworska 42**), and I arrived there in a buttoned apron with two pockets and a short coat. She received me with astonishment and fear because they were still living on **Aryan papers** and feared people would find out they were Jewish. Her husband had become a lawyer in Poznań; the Nazis had murdered their daughter, and I understood I could not stay there. However, she helped me by giving me the address of the small Jewish community in Przemyśl.

I arrived there and requested a document testifying that I am **Rachel Helpgot Weinberg**, who is searching for her family and wishes to travel to Krakow. To my astonishment, they did not want to issue me a certificate, claiming that I might be a Gentile (Goyah) and did not believe that I was Jewish.

I replied to them that I was proficient in the Tanakh and the Talmud and spoke Hebrew, and this convinced them; thus, I finally obtained an identity card. I wanted to travel toward Krakow and from there, by some means, to Israel, but I feared that the headquarters' train might still be standing at the station and they might be searching for me, and I must not take the risk.

I descended the steps of the community house, and suddenly a young woman from **Stryi** called my name: **Rachel Helpgot**. She gave me her address and invited me to her place to rest there and wait until I was sure the train had left, after which I could take a train to Krakow. It turned out she was Jewish, the daughter of a Jewish shoemaker in Stryi where we used to have shoes repaired.

I went to her house and sat on a wooden barrel and waited outside (since the Germans had already been defeated and there was no need to hide inside the barrel). Suddenly, a neighbor from across the way came out and asked: 'Are you one of ours?'. I replied 'Yes' without knowing if she meant whether I was Jewish or Christian. She invited me into her home and then told me she was going out to buy Shabbat candles—meaning she was Jewish—and she hugged me and cried and told me she had a daughter my age and the Germans murdered her... She invited me to stay overnight at her house and told me she had one son left alive, and she herself lived on false papers. On Friday evening we lit Sabbath candles and sang 'The sun from the tops of the trees has descended' [a traditional Sabbath hymn]. We wept together as if we were back before the war. I stayed to lodge with her and she offered me her own bed to sleep in. The Sabbath passed and I went out with her to the market on Monday; there, she bought me a wool blanket and would not touch my money. After four days of living with her, she brought me to the train station for the train to Krakow and we parted ways.

We traveled many hours to Krakow. Sitting next to me was a Pole who was also a repatriate returning to Poland, who treated me to a sandwich. In front of me sat two women who spoke between themselves about the 'exploits' of the Jews—that they slaughter Christian children and prepare matzah from their blood—and they added that it was a tragedy that Jews still remained and that the Nazis did not succeed in destroying them all…

I thought to myself that even after the Holocaust that the Jews went through, the hatred and antisemitism had not weakened.

In Krakow, I stayed one night in a hotel with my Aunt Hindel, who was miraculously saved from the enemy's hand. The next day I went to the market, and as if in a movie, I met Mala Lukman and Weiss Master. She told me that in Zabrze, an orphanage for Jewish children was organized who were planning to immigrate to the Land of Israel. I immediately decided that it was my duty to accept the role of a caregiver-teacher, and thus I would once again have an interest and a goal in life. In my mind, there was already a plan to immigrate with the young orphans to the Land of Israel. I arrived by an indirect route to the children's home and joined another caregiver who was there. I cared for the children with great love and wanted to provide them with some substitute for the parents the Germans had murdered. The other caregiver told me she had to travel but would return, and she asked that I hide her departure from the children; however, she did not return. I knew I had to take the toddlers to the center in Bielsko, as from there we could depart for the Land of Israel.

The Aliyah to the Land of Israel

On the way to Bielsko, we passed through Katowice, a large city in the coal-rich region of Silesia. I and the toddlers were forced to cross railroad tracks amidst mortal danger to reach the train car going to Bielsko.

Eventually, after much effort, we arrived in Bielsko. There, I handed the children over to additional caregivers, yet I continued to care for them. I also taught Hebrew to the Jewish caregivers and the older children. A few weeks later, Haganah emissaries arrived and helped us organize for the departure to the Land of Israel to establish a new home.

We traveled to Bielsko in closed trucks covered with gray, opaque tarpaulin to hide their contents, and thus we traveled for days and nights and could see nothing. We posed as Greek refugees wanting to return to Greece, in order to hide our Jewish identity. We were told that if we were addressed in Polish or German, we should act as if we did not understand and answer in Hebrew as if the Hebrew was Greek...

We traveled toward Czechoslovakia to a suburb of Prague called Hloubětín. At the border crossing between Poland and Czechia, the guide Gustav Lohman checked our knapsacks and told us to burn any evidence of our identity; thus, I burned my diary, which I had diligently kept throughout the war years. In Hloubětín, we were housed in a hotel where the signs of war were still visible; chairs were broken without seats and sofas were torn.

Afterward, we traveled toward Germany—Munich—and from there we were encouraged to travel to a port in Italy to board a ship heading toward Haifa. In Munich, we were housed in contaminated barracks that had been prepared by the Haganah in advance. From Munich, we traveled to Föhrenwald, a refugee camp not far from Munich where we were under the protection of the UN organization—UNRA [UNRRA]—for the repatriation of refugees to their countries. In this camp, conditions improved; the food and housing were much better than what we had known in Munich, and there we were able to organize study classes and temporary social groups in which I was teaching a group of children named "Dror" (sparrow) Hebrew and knowledge of the Land [of Israel], and I also worked with the group designated for settlement in Nitzanim. After several months during which we were in the refugee camp,

we set out toward the Alps in the direction of Italy. We had experienced guides who had participated in the past in moving groups of illegal immigrants (*Olim*) through the Alps to the Land. This was the "lower route."

We walked on narrow paths and parts of the snow and mud, as the snow piled up beneath our feet; on one side the Alpine mountains towered to the heart of the sky, and on the other, a gaping abyss. For days and nights we walked in the snow and passed through unmarked paths in order to enter Italy illegally without an entry visa check. When we crossed the Alps, drenched in sweat despite the biting cold, trucks were waiting for us on the other side of the Alps on Italian soil.

From the slopes of the Alps, we traveled to Genoa in closed tarpaulin trucks where air could barely penetrate, and we did not stop the entire way to relieve ourselves because we were so afraid of being caught by the authorities. Genoa is a large port city, and there we were housed in "Scuola Cadorna" (Skola Kardorna). The place was extremely filthy and the water pipes were cracked, but it didn't matter to me because next to it was that same sea that washes the shores of Haifa! and Israel.

After two months in Genoa, we moved to Bogliasco. It is a village near Nervi on the shore of the Mediterranean Sea. In Bogliasco, we stayed in a villa right on the shore of the Mediterranean. We were in Bogliasco for a long time—six months—and we organized classes for learning Hebrew, Torah, and knowledge of the Land. On the eve of Passover 1947, we were told to pack suitcases and belongings, and everyone was told to board with only one suitcase; for most people, there was nothing anyway except the clothes on their bodies. Like our forefathers, we too set out on an illegal path to ascend to the Land of Israel (*Eretz Yisrael*), while the Egyptians stood against us—in our case, the British who tried to prevent us from reaching the Land.

In Bogliasco, there was no port, so the ship could not dock at the shore. We then boarded rubber boats called "pittoni" (pontoons) and set sail on a full-moon night toward the ship. The ship was named *She'ar-Yashuv*, and it was a coal-carrying ship that was never intended for transporting people—certainly not such a large number of people; there were about 500 of us. We were housed in the belly of the ship on three levels of stretched canvas that served as crowded hammocks where we slept. The living conditions and hygiene were terrible; people vomited and relieved themselves in the belly of the ship everywhere, and sometimes we did not go out for entire days to the deck for fear of British patrol planes. Near the Greek islands, we unloaded the coal cargo, and in the space that was cleared, another two hundred immigrants joined us on the already overcrowded ship. The Greek crew was replaced on a night filled with moon and stars, and they parted from us with the song: "avanti populo lepalestina..."

It was a particularly moving moment. We were in territorial waters for three weeks until we entered the waters of Palestine. The ship was never intended for long journeys in the heart of the sea and barely withstood the storms that struck us. People cried, prayed, and vomited everywhere; above me slept an older woman who vomited incessantly, and her secretions dripped on me throughout the voyage. Almost all the passengers had seasickness, and the smell was unbearable, yet we were not allowed to go up to the deck. For many days we sailed through storms, and we bailed water out of the deck with buckets, using the few

belongings we had—like shirts and towels—to plug breaches where water penetrated the ship. I remember storms in which the ship almost descended to the depths; "the heavens were below and the sea was above.

When we finally reached the territorial waters of the Land of Israel (*Eretz Yisrael*), a British patrol plane already circled above us and announced through loudspeakers in several languages to surrender: "Have mercy on the women and children and surrender, and descend from the deck quietly." A few minutes later, two British destroyers arrived and clamped onto us from both sides with a great noise, crushing us like a nutshell. The ship's command consisted of Haganah members, and they ordered the women and children to descend into the belly of the ship; however, I, along with several other women, took iron bars in our hands, went up to the deck, and refused to go down. The British called to us through loudspeakers to surrender, while simultaneously spraying us with giant water cannons and tear gas. After a few minutes, British soldiers climbed onto the ship armed with batons and began to beat the Haganah men and the men on the deck, and they injured some of them. The battle was not fair, but we did not give up and threw at the British everything we had at hand: bottles and tin cans. We did not surrender until we sang *Hatikvah* and raised the flag of Israel on the ship's mast. Afterward, they transferred us, bruised and battered, into the belly of the destroyers to detention cells. We arrived in the belly of the destroyers at the Port of Haifa, and there we were taken off with blows from batons and threats that they would transfer us to the Mauritius Islands (distant British islands).

They loaded us in Haifa onto a prison ship headed for the detention camp in Cyprus. In Cyprus, we were brought into a detention camp with barbed wire fences, observation towers, and searchlights. The British housed us in tin shacks that were sweltering from the heat of the sun in the summer, and at night, the cold penetrated through the tin walls to the bones. Water was given in measured amounts, and only twice a day did we receive access to fresh water; we stood for hours in the sun in a line for water with buckets to receive a little drinking water. In the shacks, there were only iron beds and old cardboard boxes and wooden crates—wood and greenery were not seen at all in the camp. From a distance, we only saw the sea and dreamed of the Land of Israel.

Immediately upon arriving at the camp, I was struck by a severe depression and could not eat solid food; everything I ate, I immediately vomited. Following efforts to search for Villo and find out what his fate was, I met another woman in the DP camp in Fernwald by chance, Yehudit—a woman from Villo's hometown. Yehudit became a good friend, supported me, and fed me with a spoon until I was able to eat. I could not believe that we had already reached Haifa and seen Mount Carmel, upon which the Prophet Elijah walked, and despite having already stepped onto the soil of the Land of Israel—and despite all the suffering and hardships we went through until we reached the Land—they uprooted us by force of the British to a detention camp. We reached the gates of the Promised Land, yet we were not to enter through the gates.

In Cyprus, I also taught Hebrew and Tanakh classes for children and adults. In the camp, there were also members of the Haganah who dug a tunnel under the fences and succeeded in escaping to Israel. On November 29, 1947, we gathered around a hidden, illegal radio and heard the United Nations vote for the establishment of two states, Arab and Jewish—a home for the Jewish people in Eretz Yisrael. On May 14, 1948 (*8th of Iyar*), we

heard on the radio the declaration of the state from the mouth of Prime Minister Ben-Gurion. We thought the gates would open the next day, but the gates remained locked and the guard continued as usual.

Only about two months after the establishment of the state, in July 1948, were we released to immigrate to the Land after sixteen months in Cyprus and after three years of wandering since the end of the war—traveling from Poland through Czechoslovakia to Germany, Italy, Cyprus, and finally to Israel. After our arrival, they moved us in trucks to an immigrant camp run by Kibbutz Givat Hayim. From there, emissaries came to register us; we were like dreamers from so much happiness and excitement. I cried with joy when I saw a Hebrew soldier and a Hebrew policeman in uniform and spoke to them in Hebrew. I told the emissaries that I was a Hebrew teacher and sent a message to my uncle, Jacob Butler, the engineer living in Haifa.

He invited me to stay at his place for a while. For a few days I lived with him, as I immediately traveled to Tel Aviv to the education department to look for work. There were many offers: in a Hebrew labor school in Haifa, in a first-grade school in Rishon LeZion, and more. Finally, I was already about to sign a contract with the principal in Rishon LeZion, but at the last moment I met with Zishka Lantz, of blessed memory, who introduced me to the education supervisor, Shoshana Tzintzurovska, who directed me to Kibbutz Afek. Lantz told me that in the kibbutz I would be able to calm down and recover from the period I had gone through and not have to worry about sustenance.

Finally, I decided to move to Kibbutz Afek; apparently, this was the hand of fate. Immediately after I ascended to the Land, I searched for the sister of Villo, my husband, Berta Weinberg, who was a head nurse in Beilinson.

At Afek, I received a teaching class and taught the "Rakefet," "Kalanit," "Alon," "Nachshon," and "Shaked" classes; with these classes, I reached Bar Mitzvah age. I finished my teaching in the "Shaked" class and afterward, I moved to teaching in Ulpan Tzur Shalom, where I taught groups of immigrants and volunteers; I also worked in teaching and instruction in special education classes. At Kibbutz Afek, I met my husband Yosef Shfrir and established a family.

Upon my arrival in the Land, I looked for work in teaching; there were many options open to me, but fate led me to Kibbutz Afek, Mishmar HaYam then. In the year 1957, I was in a Bible course in Jerusalem and visited Professor A. L. Brauer, a cousin of my mother's, but I did not meet him at his home. The following letter I am attaching to my diary. I will never know the roots of the family to reconstruct. I was also with his brother, Dr. David Brauer on Mount Carmel. I have a recording of S. Y. Agnon speaking about his good friend Professor Brauer

My older daughter Shoshana & my younger daughter Yonat who is named after my beloved mother.